
African Folktales Small Language Model

Stakeholder Engagement Plan

Responsible AI, Cultural Preservation and Participatory Model Development

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Project
Domain-Specific Small Language Model for African Folktales

Year
2026

A responsible-AI engagement plan for culturally grounded, community-informed model development.

Executive Introduction

Developing an AI system around cultural heritage requires more than technical accuracy. Folktales carry community memory, moral teaching, language, performance traditions and context that may be weakened when oral knowledge is converted into digital training data. Stakeholder participation therefore helps the project identify what should be represented, what requires care or restriction, and how generated material should be described.

For this African Folktales Small Language Model (SLM), engagement is treated as an ongoing part of design rather than a one-time validation exercise. Local educators can shape educational usefulness and classroom safeguards, while cultural custodians, traditional storytellers, elders and oral-history practitioners can contribute contextual knowledge about provenance, interpretation, cultural boundaries and appropriate representation. Their participation can make the system more useful while reducing foreseeable risks of misrepresentation and decontextualisation.

1. Selected Stakeholder Groups

Local Educators and Teachers. Educators are directly relevant because the SLM may support teaching, reading, creative writing and cultural-learning activities. Their classroom experience can help determine whether outputs are age-appropriate, understandable, pedagogically useful and clearly distinguished from traditional/source folktales.

Cultural Custodians, Traditional Storytellers, Elders and Oral-History Practitioners. These participants may hold knowledge about story origins, meanings, performance conventions, language, attribution and community-specific boundaries. Their involvement is important for assessing cultural context, ownership, sensitive knowledge and respectful representation.

2. Stakeholder Values and Priorities

Educators are likely to prioritise educational relevance, readability, age-appropriateness, accessibility and clear guidance that prevents students from treating AI-generated folktale-style narratives as historical or traditional source material. Cultural custodians, storytellers and elders may place greater emphasis on authenticity, correct attribution, linguistic nuance, community ownership, consent and protection of sacred or restricted knowledge. Both groups share an interest in preserving storytelling traditions, supporting intergenerational knowledge transfer and improving representation without flattening distinct communities into a single cultural identity. They also need transparency about data provenance, model limitations and the difference between documented traditional/source folktales and newly generated narratives.

3. Potential Benefits and Harms

Stakeholder	Potential Benefits	Potential Harms
Local educators and teachers	• Accessible teaching material • Literacy and creative-writing activities • Student interest in represented traditions • AI-literacy comparisons of source and generated texts • Discussion of provenance and responsible AI	• Generated stories mistaken for historical fact • Cultural inaccuracies or misconceptions • Overreliance on AI over primary sources • Stereotypes or mixed regional traditions • Uneven community representation
Cultural custodians, storytellers, elders and oral-history practitioners	• Digital preservation and visibility • Intergenerational access • Attention to underrepresented traditions • Better attribution and provenance • Cultural expertise shaping AI	• Restricted knowledge included inappropriately • Misattribution or decontextualisation • Distorted symbols or moral lessons • Ownership or consent concerns • Marginalisation of living storytellers

4. Selected Engagement Methods

The Action Catalogue is an online decision-support resource intended to help researchers and policy-makers identify methods suited to inclusive research. For this plan, the two assignment-specified approaches are applied as complementary forms of participatory engagement: co-design workshops for educators and deliberative workshops for cultural knowledge holders. The descriptions below use established participatory principles and do not claim that the catalogue provides a specific prescription for this SLM.

Local Educators and Teachers

Participatory Design / Co-design Workshops

Cultural Custodians, Traditional Storytellers and Elders

Deliberative Workshops

5. Engagement Plan

5.1 Local Educators and Teachers

Participatory Design / Co-design Workshops

Why the method fits

Participatory design is appropriate for local educators and teachers because they are not simply future users of a finished tool; they can help define what an educationally responsible system should do. A co-design workshop creates a structured setting in which teachers can work with researchers and developers to examine the dataset, test prototypes and influence decisions before they become fixed. This is particularly important for an African Folktales SLM because usefulness depends not only on fluent generation, but also on whether outputs are readable, age-appropriate, culturally contextualised and safe to use in learning environments. Teachers can also identify where students may confuse an AI-generated folktale-style narrative with a documented traditional/source folktale.

Proposed activities across development

During dataset development, educators could review sample source materials, identify gaps in age ranges or learning themes, and flag content that needs additional context before classroom use. They could recommend educational themes, vocabulary levels and prompts drawn from real teaching needs. During model prototyping, teachers could compare authentic source folktales with generated outputs and mark inaccuracies, unclear moral lessons, inappropriate language, stereotypes or mixtures of unrelated regional traditions. In output evaluation, they could assess clarity, readability, cultural and linguistic appropriateness, and the likelihood that a learner would misinterpret generated content. Their observations could be converted into evaluation criteria and structured rubrics rather than remaining informal comments.

Influence on iterative refinement

Co-design should continue through iterative refinement and pre-deployment testing. Teachers might test different prompt formats, explanatory notices and classroom workflows, then recommend changes to system prompts, output labels or teacher guidance. For example, if students repeatedly assume a generated story is a historical folktale, the interface could display stronger provenance messaging and encourage comparison with cited source material. If outputs are too complex for a target age group, generation instructions and evaluation thresholds could be adjusted. This gives educators meaningful influence over the system rather than asking for approval after development is complete.

Expected value

Early participation can improve educational relevance, usability, cultural appropriateness and trust. It can also support responsible adoption by making limitations visible and helping teachers decide when the model is suitable for brainstorming, discussion or creative writing and when primary cultural sources are necessary. Because teachers observe how learners interpret material, they can reveal risks that may not appear in conventional model metrics. Their input can therefore complement technical evaluation with evidence about likely classroom effects and practical accessibility.

Inclusion considerations and limitations

The workshops should not treat a small group of teachers as representative of all education systems across the continent. Participants should be recruited from different represented regions, school contexts, languages and levels where feasible. Scheduling, connectivity, travel, workload and differences in digital literacy may affect participation, so sessions should allow low-bandwidth materials, printed examples and facilitated discussion where needed. Feedback should be documented with its context rather than averaged into a false consensus. Repeated engagement with different educator groups can help identify disagreements and reduce geographic or institutional bias in design decisions.

5.2 Cultural Custodians, Traditional Storytellers and Elders

Deliberative Workshops

Why deliberation fits

Deliberative workshops are appropriate for cultural custodians, traditional storytellers, elders and oral-history practitioners because their contribution extends beyond ordinary user testing. Participants may hold contextual knowledge about story origins, performance, language, symbolism, moral teaching, customary attribution and the circumstances in which particular narratives may be shared. Some questions - such as whether a story should enter a training corpus, whether knowledge is restricted, or how community ownership should be acknowledged - cannot be resolved by a technical accuracy score. Deliberation creates space to explain reasons, hear competing views and document cultural boundaries before decisions are made.

Topics for facilitated discussion

Workshops could examine whether specific stories should be included, whether attribution is adequate, and whether consent or provenance information is missing. Participants could discuss sacred, restricted or context-dependent material that should not be treated as ordinary training data. They could review generated outputs for inappropriate combinations of characters, customs, beliefs, symbols, settings or moral lessons, and distinguish creative adaptation from misrepresentation. Discussion should also cover regional differences, linguistic nuance, acceptable forms of cultural acknowledgement, and standards for clearly labelling AI-generated folktale-style narratives so they are not presented as authentic traditional/source folktales.

Why collective reasoning matters

Perspectives may differ within and across source communities. One participant may consider adaptation acceptable while another may see it as loss of meaning; expectations about attribution, access or ownership may also vary. Facilitated deliberation can surface these disagreements instead of hiding them behind a single survey score. It can reveal representation gaps, data-governance concerns and contextual knowledge that does not appear in written datasets. The goal is not to manufacture consensus, but to understand where agreement exists, where uncertainty remains, and which decisions require community-specific rules rather than a universal policy.

Inclusive participation

Engagement should recognise the diversity of African communities and storytelling traditions. Where appropriate, sessions should provide local-language facilitation, small-group discussion and oral feedback rather than relying only on written forms. Accessible venues, travel support and compensation or formal recognition for cultural expertise can reduce participation barriers. Recruitment should seek relevant variation in represented regions, genders, age groups, languages and cultural communities without claiming statistical representation of the continent. Facilitators should explain how contributions will be recorded, how recommendations will affect the project, and how sensitive comments will be handled.

Influence, accountability and limitations

Recommendations should be translated into traceable actions: removing or restricting data, improving attribution, adding metadata, changing evaluation tests, strengthening labels, or creating a correction process through which participating communities can raise concerns. A record of agreed recommendations and unresolved disagreements should be maintained transparently. No small workshop can speak for an entire country, region or continent, and community perspectives may conflict. Participation should therefore continue across dataset revision, model evaluation and deployment. Where an output concerns a specific tradition, engagement with relevant source communities is more appropriate than assuming that a general panel can authoritatively validate it.

6. Influence on Dataset and Model Design

Engagement should produce traceable design changes. Educator feedback could rebalance training examples, create age- and classroom-specific evaluation criteria, refine prompts and strengthen warnings when generated material may be mistaken for source history. Cultural custodians could recommend removing sensitive narratives, adding underrepresented community material, recording region/language/community metadata, improving attribution and documenting consent or provenance. The project can separate authentic source narratives from synthetic outputs, test for stereotyped or cross-community mixing, and label generated folktale-style narratives clearly. Both groups should also inform a correction mechanism so participating communities can report concerns and trigger review.

Stakeholder Engagement → Dataset Review → Representation & Provenance → Training / Fine-tuning → Community-informed Evaluation → Model Refinement → Ongoing Feedback

7. Conclusion

Responsible development of the African Folktales SLM requires continued participation rather than one-time consultation. Educators and cultural knowledge holders bring different forms of expertise that can shape data choices, evaluation, safeguards and use. Maintaining these engagement pathways across the model lifecycle can help the project preserve useful cultural material while remaining transparent about uncertainty, provenance and the distinction between source traditions and AI-generated folktale-style narratives.

References

Action Catalogue. (n.d.). Action Catalogue. <https://actioncatalogue.eu/>